You Know What, Teacher?

By Zenna Henderson

Miss Peterson looked resignedly around the school yard. The children swept ceaselessly from one side of the playground to the other, running madly, sometimes being jet planes, sometimes cowboys, but mostly just running. For the fourth time [she] looked at her watch. Two minutes less of noon recess than the last time she had looked.

"You know what, Teacher?" Linnet's soft little voice spoke at her elbow. "You know what my mother thinks?"

"What does your mother think?"

"My mother thinks my daddy is running around with another woman."

INTRODUCTION

Linnet is a shy first-grader who brings to school all the news from home. But in time she reveals a tragic secret to Miss Peterson, her teacher, the only person she trusts, in "You Know What, Teacher" by Zenna Henderson.

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Rain swept the closed windows with a rustly, papery sound. Miss Peterson tapped her desk bell and blessed the slight lull that followed. Rainy days were gruesome when you had to keep the children in.

"You know what, teacher?" Linnet's voice was soft by her shoulder.

"W-H-A-T. That's what!" laughed Miss Peterson, hugging Linnet's fragile body against her. Linnet considered for a moment and then smiled.

"I mean, you know what happened at our house last night?"

"No, what?"

"My mother and my daddy had a big fight. Not a hitting fight—a holler fight."

"Oh?" Miss Peterson [was] still holding Linnet in the circle of her arm.

"Yes. I listened. Daddy said Mother spent too much money and Mother said she spent it for food and rent and not on women and she got so mad she wouldn't sleep in the bedroom. She slept all night on the couch. I took her one of my blankets. It was cold."

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"That was nice of you," said Miss Peterson.

"Parents!" she thought in exasperation. "Selfish, thoughtless, self-centered . . . !

For the next few months, the state of affairs at Linnet's house could have been charted as exactly as the temperatures. When she came hollow-eyed to school to fall asleep with a crayon clutched in one hand, it was either that Daddy had come home and they'd gone to the Drive-In to celebrate, or Daddy had gone away again after a long holler fight the night before.

"You know what, teacher?" [Linnet asked one morning after a story about a bus driver]. "Last night we rode on the bus a long ways!"

"My! You must have had fun!"

"We went to find Daddy . . . Mother cried . . . All the way home. "

"Oh, that's too bad." Miss Peterson's heart turned over at the desolation on Linnet's face.

"She didn't cry until we left the motel. You know what, teacher? The lady at the motel got mixed up. She told Mother that Daddy wasn't there but that Mrs.

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Luhrs was. How could ***she*** be Mrs. Luhr when ***Mother*** is Mrs. Luhrs? ***She*** wasn't in the cabin."

"Well . . . " said Miss. Peterson.

"When we got on the bus, the money went ***ding ding*** in the box just like in our song!" said Linnet.

It makes me so mad, I could spit! Why can't that mother manage to keep ***something*** from the child? There's no reason to drag Linnet through the nasty mess. I'm kind of worried. I met Mrs. Luhrs at a PTA meeting several weeks ago. She looks – well, unstable – the mousey-looking kind that gives you a feeling of smoldering dynamite—if dynamite can smolder. Poor Linnet.

Several weeks later, Linnet leaned against Miss Peterson's desk and asked, "How much more until lunch, teacher? I'm hungry."

"Not very long, Linnet. What's the matter, didn't you eat a good breakfast this morning?

"I didn't eat ***any*** breakfast. I got up too late. I almost missed the bus."

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"You better tell your mother to get you up earlier!"

"She didn't wake up either. The doctor gave her some sleeping stuff so she won't cry at night, and she didn't hear the alarm clock. She said one morning without breakfast wouldn't hurt me. But I'm hungry."

Then, about a week later, Linnet came to school resplendent in a brand-new dress, carrying a huge box of crayons. "Even a gold, and a silver and a ***white*** one, teacher!" She was jiggling around excitedly, her newly set curls bobbing with an animation they hadn't shown in months.

"You know what, teacher? Daddy came home last night! I woke up and I heard him tell Mother he was through with that double-crossing b**** and he'd never go away again!"

It lasted a month. Then Linnet crept around in the schoolroom, not even caring when Henry took her white crayon and chewed it into a crumbled mess. Three trembling fingers crept up to cover a trembling mouth.

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She forgot simple words she had known for months, and she cried before trying new ones.

One day the reading group laughed over the story of Spot dragging the covers off Sally to wake her up. They all had wide-eyed stories to tell about how hard ***they*** were to wake up or how incredibly early they woke up by themselves.

"You know what, teacher? That's just like Daddy and Mother this morning," said Linnet softly. "They didn't get out of bed, so I fixed my own breakfast and got ready for school, all by myself.

"My, you're getting to be a big girl, aren't you?"

"Yes. I went into their bedroom [and] I pulled the covers up for Mother because her shoulders were cold. Her nightgown hasn't got any sleeves,"

When Linnet brought up the smudged, straggly writing paper that had replaced her former neat and legible ones, Miss Peterson wondered why this morning, when Daddy was home, Linnet's work hadn't improved.

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"You know what, teacher? Last night Mother promised she wouldn't cry any more, not ever again. And she said Daddy won't ever go away again."

"Isn't that fine? Now you can have lots of fun together, can't you!"

Linnet turned her head away. "Daddy doesn't like me anymore."

"Oh, surely he does—all daddies love their little girls."

"My daddy doesn't. Mother let me take him a cup of coffee last night while she was doing the dishes. He drank it and said, "Hell, even the coffee around here is enough to turn your stomach. Beat it, brat" And he pushed me and I dropped the empty cup and it broke.

"But if he isn't going away any more – "

"Mother told me ***that.***" Linnet's eyes were full of unchildlike wisdom. "She told me lots of times before. But she didn't hear Daddy swear."

"Well, it will be nice if your mother doesn't cry anymore."

"Yes. When she cries, I cry too."

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Miss Peterson watched Linnet go back to her table and start her fun-paper. Poor cherub, she thought.

"Do you suppose I ought to do something about it?" she asked Miss Estes in the cafeteria.

"Do what? Call the sheriff because a father swore at his child and called her a brat?"

"You know it's more than that. An unwholesome home environment."

"What would you do? Take her away from them? In that case you'd have to take half the kids in the nation away from their parents. Nope, as long as she's fed and clothed and carries no visible scars, you can't invoke the law."

[Later that day], after the buses had gone, Miss Peterson saw a lonely figure sitting by the swings.

"Hi, teacher! Mother told me not to come home on the bus today. She said someone would come after

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me." Linnet was opening and shutting a little blue-and-white box.

"What's that?" asked Miss Peterson.

"It's empty. Mother got this at the drugstore yesterday. It had medicine in it ***then***. It was Mother's sleeping stuff." Linnet snapped the box shut again. "You know what, teacher? She put an awful lot of sugar in Daddy's coffee before I took it to him, and he doesn't like very much sugar. Maybe that's why he got mad last night."

"Where did you get this box, Linnet?"

"It was on Mother's dresser, by her coffee cup. When I went in this morning to see if they were awake, I found it. It was empty."

Miss Peterson sat eyeing the box for a long minute. Of course it couldn't be. Children so often exaggerate and draw mistaken conclusions. But . . .

"Let's play something while you're waiting. Let's play What Comes Next. You know, like we do with the picture stories in our workbooks."

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"Okay, Teacher!" Linnet's eyes lighted with pleasure

"Now, last night, your mother poured your Daddy's coffee. What Comes Next?"

"Oh, you missed a What Comes Next!" Linnet laughed. "***[First]*** Mother put a lot of the sleeping stuff in Daddy's cup. She said Daddy was getting restless. ***Then*** she poured the coffee."

"Then you took it to your Daddy?"

"Uh-uh! First I had to get Mother a hankie because she was crying. ***Then*** I took it to Daddy."

"And then your daddy drank it. What Comes Next?"

"I don't know."

"You said you dropped the cup . . . "

"Yes . . . I dropped the cup when Daddy got mad and pushed me." The two sat in silence a while . . .

"When it got dark, you got ready for bed and your mother and daddy said good night."

"Not Daddy. He went to bed before I did last night. He yawned and yawned and went to bed. And

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then I went to bed and Mother woke me up [this morning] and told me she wouldn't ever cry again and that Daddy wouldn't ever leave her again. And then . . . and then . . . Oh, teacher. You know what? She gave me a note to give to you! She put it in my shoe so I wouldn't lose it."

She pulled off the scuffed little oxford and fished inside it. Finally she came up with two grimy pieces of paper.

Miss Petersen sat in the swaying s wing and she wished with all her heart that she didn't have to read the note:

Please don't let Linnet ride the bus home. Call AR 2-9276 when school is over. Ask them to keep her for a day or two until her grandmother comes. Thank you.

Linnell Luhrs

"What does it say, teacher?"

"It says for you not to go home on the bus. You're to wait."

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She looked down at the cramped, close-written line that slanted sharply below the signature.

God forgive me. I couldn't let him go away again.

"Well," said Miss Peterson. "I have to go to the office and make a phone call. You say here and play. Remember, don't move away from here."

"You know what, teacher?"

"No, what?

"It's kinda lonesome here, all alone . . . "

"Yes it is, dear," said Miss Peterson, blinking against the sting in her eyes. "It is kinda lonesome, all alone."

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